

Robert Clay Grubbs
Dr. Justin Carpenter
ENGL 6480
November 8, 2024

***Katana ZERO*: Feedback Loops and Iterative Hermeneutics**

“I don’t make snuff films,” is what the fittingly named protagonist of *Katana ZERO*, Subject Zero, claims when given the offer to collaborate on one by V, one of the game’s primary antagonists. But despite this claim, *Katana ZERO* is a game that’s seemingly all about making snuff films. The player is afforded control of this Zero, a twenty-two year old, katana-wielding assassin operating under the directions of his psychiatrist. Before his missions, this psychiatrist medicates him with Chronos, a drug that bestows him the power of precognition: the ability to see potential outcomes of the future. Chronos is what diegetically permits the gameplay loop; any time the player dies or runs out of time, the level resets, as though that attempt was a failed imagining of Zero’s success. In order for Zero to successfully complete missions, the player takes control of him within this precognitive state and attempts to find a solution to the current level. The player will cycle through enough failed attempts at clearing the room of enemies, and eventually stumble into a course of action that keeps Zero alive and leaves everyone else dead. The screen then goes black, projects a simple line, “Yes, that should work,” and plays a black and white VHS recording of Zero’s execution of this precognitive solution and of anyone in the room, while the player is left to watch. So, yes, this is a game about making snuff films, or rather, the process of figuring out how to make snuff films.

The gameplay during precognition, and therefore these psychiatrist assigned missions, is that of an action platformer: the player can control Zero by moving him left or right, with the ability to jump upwards to higher platforms, and the ability to fall onto lower platformers. Each

precognitive loop holds a single level as its subject, which usually hold multiple floors filled with smaller rooms, wherein enemies are placed, as well as an entrance and exit. There are a variety of enemy types, which can most simply be characterized as melee fighters or ranged gunmen and turrets. On top of their general movement, the player is given the offensive abilities to attack with their sword, which can also redirect or parry a bullet when well-timed, and to pick up and throw objects. As for defense, they can dodge, which gives them a moment of invulnerability capable of avoiding melee attacks or bullets, and to slow down time for a period limited by a meter, which refills when not being used. With these verbs, and the looping function of precognition, the player is tasked with either killing or sometimes sneaking past every enemy to reach the end of a given level.

To consider this gameplay loop more clearly, partially defining it under Cardona et. al's MDA-GFI framework will help contextualize the total process of play. The mechanics (M), which comprise "the components of the game at the level of data representation and algorithm," are simply definable as the rules that facilitate interaction within the game's system, or the system itself. The spatial structure of the level, the enemies and their behaviors, as well as the player's list of abilities, including precognition, all fall under this category. The goals (G) which are the "conditions players are expected to meet to succeed at a game," which drive the player's mechanical action, are to kill or avoid all enemies, and reach the end of the level within the permitted amount of time. The dynamics (D) of combat play out as the "the run-time behavior of the mechanics acting on player inputs," which produce feedback, (F,) "multi-modal stimuli" that represents the structure of these dynamics and the game's "underlying ends (goals) and the available means to achieve them (mechanics)".

This feedback of dynamics, the visual representation of combat, informs the player's interpretation (I): their "situated process of deriving meaning from enaction" as well as the outcomes of that process. The process of meaning-making from feedback is described as the movement from "a player's existing interpretation of the game's narrative into a preferred interpretation," (7). Feedback is received at a baseline phonological, and therefore narratological level (6). And since feedback then displays both the game's narrative and ludological structures, in *K0*, precognition works as a feedback loop to facilitate this process of interpretation. An existing, or non-preferred interpretation of the game's narrative could be considered any failed attempt at a level. In ludological terms, a fail-state is reached, meaning the player misunderstood, or misinputted, the correct interpretation of dynamics necessitated by the system. And on the narrative side of this fail-state, Zero acknowledges the misalignment of action, "No...That won't work." The feedback is given, the player readjusts their interpretation of the system, and loops through this process of adjustment until their interpretation is correctly aligned and enacted. The system then confirms the player's action by replaying their solution back to them as though it were taped, and *Katana ZERO*'s narrative becomes the outcome of successful feedback interpretation.

This process is functionally one of hermeneutics. In *S/Z*, Barthes describes the hermeneutic code as the ways in which "an enigma" can be "held in suspense, and finally disclosed," (19). In short, it's a question asked, with an answer held in suspense. The entrance into a level, and the first sight of the level immediately beg the question of how you, as Zero, are going to get to the exit, whilst killing or avoiding anyone in your way. Or, in terms of MDA-GFI, how the goal of exiting a room can be articulated through mechanics into dynamics. The goal is obstructed by the enigma of any interaction that could lead to a fail-state, which obscures a

preferred interpretation of the given feedback. This enigma is formulated at first glance; its “subject,” Zero, or the player, as well as its “statement of the question,” the introduction of the new level with its enemies, and the “question mark,” gesturing towards player input (Barthes, 84). The room, which includes all of its mechanics as well as its goal, is revealed through feedback, and the enigma is proposed, begging for interpretation.

So the player attempts to answer this total question, to interpret it in its preferred sense, which includes each individual obstacle, or enemy needing to be killed. “The interpretation outcome is what defines a narrative goal: the meaning derived from a ludological goal,” and those ludological goals form around obstacles. Obstacles, or the “prevention” of a goal, are categorized as “imperative goals” which are necessary to the completion of the “ultimate goal” of a level, which “determines its end conditions,” (4). These imperative goals, and enemies in *K0*, can be thought of as delays in the resolution of the enigma, a primary function of the code as a given text must “*maintain* the enigma in the initial void of its answer,” by setting up these “*delays* (obstacles, stoppages, deviations) in the flow of discourse,” (Barthes, 75). The answer to the enigma, the preferred narrative interpretation, is disrupted by these obstacles of enemy encounters. The player must then mechanically deal with each and every one of these obstacles, figuring a specific solution in combat. For instance, each enemy type has an attack pattern that facilitates a different response from the player. An enemy with a rifle will fire one or two bullets at Zero once he enters their line of vision. This can be responded to with a couple different options: killing the soldier before he fires the gun, dodging the bullet and killing the soldier, or using your sword to parry the bullet. Each of these, when executed in play, constitute a means of progressing past a delay, therefore a partial answer to the level’s enigma, and a preferred interpretation of these units of feedback.

The levels complicate these solutions by placing many different types of enemies in clusters, which form complex delays, or grammatical units of imperative goals. The grammatical level of feedback is described as “stimuli structured according to a corresponding syntax,” (). If goals are revealed through the interpretation of singular obstacles, which can be arranged grammatically, then goals can be arranged grammatically too. For instance, a room filled with more gunmen than an average player can handle might be filled with red explosive barrels. The player receives the visual information of the room, which formulates an enigma and allows them to interpret the mechanical syntax of the structure. A player might find a resolution by fighting their way out with the core combat system or dodging, rolling, and parrying in time with each of the enemies. Or, a player might opt to toss a molotov found elsewhere in the level towards the door, combusting the red barrels, killing all enemies in the room. Both of these solutions formulate an answer to the complex delay through interpreting the preferred syntax, and therefore act as a partial resolution of the total enigma of the level. The eventual, total resolution of the enigma, and the ultimate goal, can also then, be thought of as a larger grammatical unit relationally composed of the preferred interpretation of each obstacle’s syntax. And to answer the question of the enigma, is to close the narrative of the level, as Barthes describes an enigmas disclosure as “the final stroke by which the initial ‘probable’,” or the existing interpretation, “shifts to the ‘necessary’,” the preferred interpretation (188). And in the preferred interpretation’s finality, “the game is ended, the drama has its denouement, and the subject correctly ‘predicated’ (fixed),” (188). Zero leaves the room and kills every enemy without being hit, and is recorded doing it.

The way in which precognition reveals this feedback to Zero is by an assumedly framed narrative. Zero’s ability to imagine the future manifests in something akin to a dream of reality,

an acted-out snuff film. He receives this vision, and depending on its ability to fully resolve the enigma of the room, either rejects or accepts it. Precognition is then a *mise-en-abyme* of the ultimate narrative and ludological goals of the level. In *The Mirror in the Text*, Lucien Dallenbach describes the characteristics of *mise-en-abyme* as “any internal mirror that reflects the whole of the narrative,” (36). Since the whole narrative of the level is a specific grammatical response to every obstacle, precognition then reflects a story of the *whole* of the level’s narrative back unto Zero, as well as the player, defining its potential narratives as *mise-en-abyme*.

Dallenbach first outlines the narrative function of *mise-en-abyme* by its placement in the text as an *utterance*. This kind of *mise-en-abyme* is defined as an “intertextual résumé or quotation of the content of a work,” a kind of summarized reference to the text doing the summarizing (55). This allows the text to look back at itself and “consequently gives rise to internal repetition,” (55). The text, and in this case, the level, generates from this internal repetition the means by which it can interpret itself. Through precognition, Zero and the player are able to interpret the full syntax of a level’s enigma, which is presupposed by precognition’s existence; there is a goal, a preferred interpretation, that can be found through repetition and reflection. The gameplay loop then embodies the internally repetitive state of *mise-en-abyme*, the ability for a text to recursively generate, and facilitate its own meaning-making. The precognitive *mise-en-abyme* is a prophetic feedback loop in which the level dynamically generates a solution to itself.

This recursive self generation is made possible through the process of interpretation, the receiving of the embedded narrative by a reader, which then reflects the whole of the reading process, as well as the code of the system. The receiving of *mise-en-abyme* facilitates the ability for its diegetic addressee to, move “from ignorance to knowledge,” by appearing as an

exemplum that urges the receiver to correctly interpret the truth, the truth being what structures the *mise-en-abyme* “in terms of this ultimate goal,” (82). A *mise-en-abyme* is then directly definable as the category of feedback within MDA-GFI, which facilitates the player’s ability to move from ignorance to the preferred interpretation of the ultimate goal. Feedback makes interpretation possible by reflecting the total structure of the text, as “the textual reflection is *always also a mise-en-abyme* of the code,” which reveals the underlying syntax of meaning (98). Precognitive feedback affords the player the ability to decipher the reflection of the level’s code through its display of mechanics and goals. By reflecting these coded structures, feedback is allowed to “operate as ‘instructions’ to enable the reader to perform his/her task more easily,” (99-100). An accomplishable ultimate goal, and the preferred interpretation presupposed by this goal, are made possible through precognition’s ability to reflect underlying structure and syntax of a level’s units.

The preferred response to this duplication, is then itself duplicated, as the player-resolved snuff film is enacted by Zero on tape. It summarizes the precognitive *mise-en-abyme*’s process of system summarization and therefore summarizes the system as well. It affirms the notion that the system and its mechanics are simultaneously dynamic and static. If this terminal *mise-en-abyme* summarizes the whole system in a singulative form that must still “conform to the code of credibility that has hereto ruled the text”, then it’s simply a narrative instance that, told in past tense, reaffirms “*what is already known*” by the system, a solution to its ultimate goal (65). The precognitive loop is a *mise-en-abyme* that reflects the total dynamics of the system, whereas the terminal tape reflects the static nature of this system in respect to its ultimate goal. Precognition is therefore a naturally repetitive process of enacting a prophecy, an enigmatic resolution, which is only revealed through its enactment. The player becomes a “reader of his/her own adventure

enacted by him/herself,” and precognition affords Zero awareness of the solution to a level as he attempts to solve it (90). The enigma’s resolution was always predetermined, and the narrative of a level already over before it could begin.

But given the fact that the static summary of the achieved ultimate goal is also a reflection precognitive process of its actualization through the total system, it constructs an iterative narrative of that process in retrospect. Precognition, the reflection of the level’s system, might initially seem definable by Gerard Genette’s definition of multiple singulative narrative, where the work narrates “n times what happened n times,” (115). Precognition narrates each individual attempt of clearing a room, exactly as many times as it takes to occur, making it functionally appear singulative. But, the actual narration of precognition is more complicated than this, as n is determined by the number of player interpretations formed, and therefore the number of attempts it takes to reach its singulative predetermined goal. N is dependent on the player’s intervention in the internally repetitive *mise-en-abyme*. The single instance (1) of a preferred interpretation of the system narrates, via generative repetition, the number of attempts taken to complete it (n). And Genette’s model of the iterative is described as, “narrating one time (or rather: at one time) what happened n times,” (116) which seems to more aptly categorize the iterative, predestined arrival of precognition.

These iterative structures, in which a single structure defines a potentially infinite series of narrated events, are defined by three specific terms: determination, specification, and extension. Determination is the total time frame in which the iterative events occurred, specification describes how frequently the event narrated happened in the determined period, and extension is the amount of time a singulative instance took. In the case of *Katana ZERO*’s precognition, extension varies from attempt to attempt, and is determined by the mechanics and

dynamics. Specification is every attempt, and determination becomes the product of specification and extension: the total length of a given level's gameplay. And being that, determination of precognition is always described as the amount of time between entering a level and achieving its ultimate goal, therefore, every imperative goal. The generative loop of precognition closes when all of the delays, or obstacles, in the hermeneutic code are solved, and the narrative becomes fixed.

The resolutions to these delays, both simple and complex, can be defined by Genette's conception of internal determination, where a division inside of an iterative series can "easily punctuate its stages, and divide it into subseries," (130). The internal determination of precognition is those attempts in which the player correctly interprets the feedback of a given obstacle, such as tossing a molotov to kill every guard in the room with red barrels. Those minor enigmas are resolved, and the iterative narrative is segmented into a linear sequence of two subseries: no solutions/partial solution. And it continues this process of iterative hermeneutic summation, until the ultimate goal of internal repetition has been reached. Zero has found his solution and will act, recorded on VHS, for our ability to watch. "Yes, that should work," and we are left to witness and participate in the same act. We see our own solutions enacted, reproduced back to us, reflecting our solutions which were, in and of themselves, a reproduction of the system's ultimate goal. Precognition can now end, and with that the iterative loop closes, only to start again seconds later, with the proposition of a new room, and a new predetermined enigma.

But it's important to note that the achievement of a preferred interpretation is not necessarily a one-to-one understanding of the ultimate goal of a level. The interpretation facilitated through iterative feedback, this *mise-en-abyme* of precognition "can only put forward a fiction or metaphor" of an originating reality that's "already out of reach, or already

duplicated,” (Dallenbach, 101). Feedback in and of itself only produces a metaphoric ultimate goal that’s enacted by the player. The fact that there are many different means of resolving the total enigma of a level is illustrative of this point. The desire of the system, an actual center or origin for the preferred interpretation, is always obscured by the fact that feedback itself is codified. In fact, precognition’s failure to solidify an origin point, or a strict answer to how the level should be played, reflects what Dallenbach describes as the *transcendental mise en abyme*, the "code of codes" (106) that produces the capacity to reflect on the meaning making process itself. We, as players, are left floating in the generative space created by the system, aware of its meaning-making syntax, aware of *a* preferred interpretation, but never able to grasp *the* preferred interpretation. Then, if no achieved ultimate goal is a decisive origin, everything generated, and accepted by the system, becomes a center. As language, feedback, and meaning-making slip into a total circularity, their arbitrariness becomes hard to deny; this centerless, systemic circle then forces the player to recognize its virtuality, and the arbitrary syntax of games as whole.